

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Lent 4

The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love

Edge Walking

15 March 2026



"Gray and Gold" by American artist John Rogers Cox, 1941

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Organ & Film - Adapted for The Great Organs of First Church by C. Bull:

Opening of *Also sprach Zarathustra* (Richard Strauss) and *The Blue Danube* (Johann Strauss)
from *2001: A Space Odyssey*

Air in D Major (Johann Sebastian Bach) from *Moonraker*

Vide Cor Meum (Patrick Cassidy) from *Hannibal*

March of the Resistance (John Williams) from *The Force Awakens*

O Fortuna (Carl Orff) from *Excalibur*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Shalonda Martin

Holy One, you have set us free,
not free to do anything we please,
but free to love you with our whole hearts.
So, this Lenten morning we ask, O God,
free us to love our neighbors as ourselves.
Holy One, we ask to know your freedom.

And while we are at it, God,
free us from selfishness,
free us from our indifference to people in need,
free us to love you with everything we are,
and everything we have.
Holy One, help us to live your freedom.

And then, O God,
free us to show compassion to all those who have been cast aside –
outcasts *and* outlaws –
free us to share generously so that none will lack
the basic necessities of life.
And free us to live in love,
understanding we are responsible for each other.
Holy One, help us to share the good news of your freedom.

God, we ask for the freedom to love you with our hearts and souls and minds and strength,
the freedom to truly love our neighbors as ourselves,
and the freedom to live in the ways that you have dreamed for our world...
Holy One, this day we ask for freedom! [adapt/csine]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering**

In Unity, We Gather

LANCASHIRE

In unity we gather, rejoicing in this place;
We come from many cultures, diverse in creed and race.
Our voices blend together to praise Creative Love,
To sing of beauty dwelling among us and above.

We celebrate our oneness within diversity,
Our varied voices joining, creating harmony.
Together in the music all talents will increase,
And with Creative Wisdom we open paths of peace.

Through sharing of our music we build community;
The great Creative Spirit inspires our synergy.
The clapping trees and rivers are joining in our praise,
And all creation vibrates with songs of joy we raise.

In faith we are united, in hope and love set free;
Through bridging our divisions we claim all we can be.
Together we envision a peaceful global home;
Within Creative Myst'ry we find a deep Shalom.
-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Eternal God, this morning,
open our hearts so that we may know
we are always held in your encircling love.
You, O God, know and recognize our deepest needs.

Your grace is like living waters that can never be exhausted.
You bathe us in your Spirit and yearn for our welfare,
as a mother yearns for her children.
You are in the arid desert as well as green pastures,
and will help us to grow in both places.

*Help us, O God, to know that our journey
does have a purpose and that our path leads to
places and edges we cannot yet imagine.*

We thank you for those who travel with us on this Lenten journey,
and pray that in this time of worship
we will refresh one another as you refresh us.

*We pray this as people who long
to know, and live, in your goodness
and the freedom of your love!*

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

“Welcome Back, Your Soul”
Laude

WILLIAM MALPEDE

***The Lord’s Prayer for Lent**

Shalonda Martin

*Loving Presence, luminous in all creation,
hallowed be your name.
Thy kin-dom come.
May we reflect on earth
the yielding perfection of the heavens.*

*Help us to receive an illumed measure from the earth this day.
Forgive us when we trespass against others,
human and other than human,
as we forgive others who trespass against us.
Keep us on the path of wisdom
when we are tempted to take the selfish path.
May it be your rule we follow,
your power we exercise,
and your radiance that allures.*

*May this be the truth that guides our lives,
the ground from which our future will grow,
until we meet again.*
Amen and Amen!

[BSanguin/dddc]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

Not because we have made peace this day,
not because we have always treated the other as self,
not because we have walked the earth with reverence today...
but because there is mercy,
because there is grace,
because God’s Spirit is always and forever with us.

We come this morning thirsting for peace,
longing to love, hungering for new ways of being.

So, as we share this ancient greeting with each other again,
may it be the peace of God we welcome
in our hearts, minds, bodies, and spirits.

*May this peace be the well of strength from which we share
and work for peace in our communities and lives.*

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
from the Gospel of Luke

Shalonda Martin & Rev. Fregin

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of Solidarity,
Thank you for being a God who enters the suffering of the world -
who doesn't run from those in pain but rushes to the site of blood, of tears.

Release us from empty cravings of unity that come at no cost to the oppressor,
and guide us toward a solidarity that demands something of us.

Let us learn to risk ourselves on behalf of the vulnerable,
believing that when one of us is harmed, we all are.

Help us to remember that justice and liberation are not a scarcity,
and that our survival and dignity are wrapped up in one another.

And God, keep us from those who will demonize the fight in us.
Who would prefer us complacent and far from one another.

Secure in us the courage to stand in the edge spaces,
knowing together we will restore what the world has tried to suffocate in us.

-Cole Arthur Riley

Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"Not While I'm Around" from Sweeney Todd
Frank Hobbs, *Soloist*, Christoph Bull, *Piano*

STEPHEN SONDHEIM

Sermon

Edge Walking

Rev. Michael Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Shalonda Martin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Duel of the Fates"
Cathedral Choir

JOHN WILLIAMS

"Under the tongue root, a fight most dread, and another raging, behind in the head."

***Lenten Doxology**

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

***Offering Prayer**

Shalonda Martin

Eternal God, in the days to come,
may your presence expand and enhance our lives.
May our gratitude for life be expressed in our generosity.
May our faith be expressed in good causes.
And may our belief in the future find full expression
in the way we love and care for each other,
and for our world. [adapt/fmacnab]

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

May we walk softly, mindful of the dignity that rests in every soul,
especially those the world casts aside.
Let our steps be tender and our hearts open,
as we tend to the beauty within each person.

*May our lives be a testament to a world
where all are seen and nurtured,
and where every life has the space to bloom
in its fullest, most radiant form.
We will go as kin, bound by love and dignity.*
-Kat Armas

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Golden" from KPop Demon Hunters
Cathedral Choir

EJAE, MARK SONNENBLICK,
24, IDO, & TEDDY
LYONS

***Hymn for the Journey**

O Spirit of Power

O Spirit of Power, who dwells in us all,
Inspire us each hour to follow your call.
Awaken our vision to all we can be,
And challenge our labor to set people free.

Though many your names, Love reigns over all;
With you we can claim our life-giving call.
Cast out all our fear so with you we can soar,
Creating a world never dreamed of before.

O Spirit of Love, compassionate Friend,
Within and above, your strength knows no end.
Your rivers of healing revive thirsty land;
All goodness and nourishment flow from your hand.

O Spirit of Power, O Love beyond thought,
Our gifts with you flower; what wonders are wrought.
Creator, Redeemer, and Comforting Guide,
Illumine our lives as with you we abide.

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

March of the Resistance - Reprise (John Williams)

Inside The Music

"My first response to watching "KPop Demon Hunters," after the sheer joy of the music, was how well it aligned with the messages of our community. The moment when they sing "Golden" and everyone joins with them to bring peace to the world as Rumi overcomes Gwi-Ma's control still makes me emotional. I love that in their world, music is central to the universal wellbeing. And, this is why movies matter. They give us opportunities to connect with ourselves in dream-like mental states filled with possibility. The world celebrates the Industry today with the Oscars, and we're celebrating in our service. I'm hopeful that Huntrix wins an award this week. Regardless, they have brought messages of acceptance, diversity, mental health awareness, and peace to a wide swath of the world coated in infectious music and fun. "Sweeney Todd" did a similar thing, though through a macabre lens. After a long life on the stage, Tim Burton and Sondheim worked together to bring a new version to the silver screen in 2007. The most tender moment in the story happens with "Not While I'm Around." As a dangerous world gets closer to Tobias, and Mrs. Lovett realizes that her actions have fueled that danger, she and Tobias sing to one another. Their duet (sung as a solo by Frank) is a reminder of a brighter future we all hope for ourselves and our children. Sadly for Mrs. Lovett, she has chosen to forfeit that future for the cause of revenge. In this song she finds a redemption that encourages the next generation to make new choices. Billy Malpede has been singing with us for a few months while his church choir is taking a short break. He has been featured as the composer and orchestrator for a number of films. He has also written a number of choral works, and we are grateful to get to sing an excerpt from his

engaging “Welcome Back, Your Soul” this week. The text encourages sensory awareness. As we drink in the sights, sounds, and smells of the world around us, we feel our soul return with a warm welcome. His off beat accompaniment sparkles in our ears, drawing our attention outward as the voices travel harmonically. He begins in B major. The next lines see the lowering of notes that create new key centers. As the soul returns, he raises other notes for still new key areas before returning back to an expansively new B chord on “soul.” The music is a reminder that this welcome, our connection to ourselves, is an ever moving experience that invites regular attention and a perpetual welcoming. John William’s “Duel of the Fates” from “The Phantom Menace” appears in the battle where Qui Gon Jinn and the Darth Maul perish. On it’s surface, it would appear that the global theme of a fight between light and darkness were the point of the piece. Yet, Williams gave us a different perspective with his choice of an ancient Sanskrit text. The “tongue root” draws attention to our outward conflicts, the kind that Qui Gon Jinn and the Darth Maul were engaged in. These are the most easy to define. They are the immediate challenges that we translate into binaries and approach with clarity. The other “fight most dread,” however, is raging “in the head.” After the binaries have been settled, we are still left with complexity. Our minds spin and obsess. We wrestle with who we are and who others are. We worry over jealousies and inadequacies. Our minds are the seed of our own challenges. When unmet, they lead us to shape the world into binaries to conquer. When we develop tools to receive the world and our complex selves we change the structure of our experience. This is the edge we walk. It is Rumi’s reality that she is both human and demon. When she learns to embrace the fullness that is herself, she returns to who she is, and heals the world in the process. I’m not sure how only Yoda ever really figures that out in the Star Wars series, but that’s a debate for another time, and probably reveals the nuances in front of us as we seek balance and peace in our own lives.”~ Dr. David Harris